

Stay

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Tape 1: The Reason I'm Doing This

The book is a recording. Plain text is Wren, talking into the dictaphone — spoken, not written; read it as a voice. The cues in italics — (beat), (a long breath) — are the sound of the machine: the pauses, the room, the running tape. They are also the clock; watch what happens to them. [Bracketed italics] are the one who assembled the tapes — Liss's daughter, the never-woken child, the person Wren is talking to — reconstructing, too late, with love. See the README.

[There are seven of these. I don't know that's all of them. I know it's all the ones I have. I have spent a long time deciding what order to put them in, and I have decided to stop deciding, and just go by the only thing I can trust, which is what she says. She says, on this one, that she's starting. So this one is first.]

You should know before you begin: I am the person she is talking to. She says "you," and she means me. I have thought about taking that out — about turning her toward the wall instead, so you could listen without being implicated. I can't. It's the truest thing on the tapes, that she's talking to someone. So you'll be me, for a while. I'm sorry. It's the only way I know to let her be heard.]

(A click. Room tone — a small room, soft, the hum of a fridge somewhere through a wall. A chair. Then her voice, close to the machine, dry, certain, the voice of someone who has decided to do a hard thing and is doing it.)

Right. *(beat)* So. This is on. The little light's on. *(a small dry sound)* I've been carrying this thing around for a week not turning it on, which is — that's me all over, isn't it. Buy the thing, hold the thing, build a whole speech about the thing, and then —

(beat)

Liss bought it for me. I want that on the record, since this is a record. My sister bought me a dictaphone, the kind a doctor would've used forty years ago, found it in a drawer of somebody's cleared-out house, and she put it in my hand and she said — she didn't say *talk into it*. She's careful, my sister, she's learned to be careful with me the way you're careful with a person who flinches. She said: *leave yourself something*. *(beat)* That's what she said. *Leave yourself something, in case.*

(a long breath)

In case. *(beat)* You'd know all about *in case*, wouldn't you. You grew up in *in case*. The two of us raising you with one eye always on the door — I'm sorry about that, by the way, I've been meaning to say it where it'd stay said. We did our best and our best had a draught coming off it you could feel from the next room. *(beat)* But that's not this. This is a different *in case*. This one's mine.

(beat)

Let me do the hard part first, while I've still got — while it's still just me in here. *(beat)* I'm going to have a baby. *(a breath)* There. Said into a machine, out loud, in a quiet room. Three more weeks, give or take;

she's low, the midwife says, she's ready, she's a good size, she turned when she was meant to. A girl. *(beat)* I'm forty-six years old and I'm having a daughter, and I married a man who loves me, and I have a small house with a fridge that hums, and by every account, including my own, this is the best thing that has ever happened to me. *(beat)* I want you to hear me say that and mean it. Write it down. *She was happy.* Whatever comes after on these tapes — and something's coming, that's the whole reason for the tapes — you hold on to the fact that the woman at the start of it was *happy*, and not stupid, and not asking for it. *(very quiet)* I'd had so little for so long. And then I had the lot.

(The tape runs. Nothing. Then:)

And I'm terrified. *(beat)* Not the way you're meant to be. Not — *what if I drop her, what if I don't love her enough*, the ordinary terrors, I'd give a finger for the ordinary terrors. *(beat)* I'm terrified because I am the one person in the whole history of my family who knows exactly what might be about to happen, and I can't tell a single soul who'd believe me, except a machine, and you, after.

(beat)

So let me tell it to you straight, the way I was never told anything straight, the way I've had to dig every true thing out of myself with my fingernails. *(beat)* You know most of it. You sat and listened to the other tapes — the long ones, the ones I made about Daniel and your mother and the house. I talked into the dark for years so you'd have it. So I won't do all that again. *(beat)* But here's the spine of it, the one sentence, the thing I need sitting under everything else I say:

(beat)

A child of my family is born with the — there's a thing inside, a — *(she gropes; this is the sound to remember; she is reaching for a word across a gap)* — call it a door. Born with a door in them. And the door doesn't open by itself. It has to be opened from the other side, by someone who's already got theirs open, when you're small, before you've got a — before there's a *you* there to mind. *(beat)* That's how they make a new one. They open the door on a baby and the baby goes through and stops being a separate anyone, ever. *(beat)* That's the whole engine. That's what was done to your mother and her mother and back and back past the word for back. *(beat)* And it's what *wasn't* done to me. They tried. It didn't take. The door's in me — I can feel the draught of it some nights, I always could — but it never opened, and so I got to be a person, by accident, by a failure, which is the only reason I could ever — *(beat)* — which is the only reason I could love your mother across the gap that one night, and love you, badly, across the gap your whole life. The door staying shut is the worst thing that ever happened to me and it's the only good thing in me. I've made my peace with that. Took thirty years.

(beat)

And it's what wasn't done to *you*. *(beat)* Now listen, because this is the part that's supposed to keep me safe, and I want you to hear me leaning on it, so that later, if it gives way, you'll have heard exactly how much weight I put on it. *(beat)* You've got the door too. Course you have. You're your mother's daughter; it's in you same as it's in all of us. But yours never opened either, and we know *why* yours never opened — because by the time you were born there was no one left with an open door to open it. The chord was dead. Your mother got out; I never got in; the old ones are gone. There was nobody home to wake you. *(beat)* So you grew up dark and safe and ordinary and faintly *off* in a way no one could name, same as me, and you're fine. You're a grown woman and you're fine. *(beat)* And I have watched you be fine for — for your whole life, and I have thought, every single day: *if she's fine, I'm fine*. Same door. Same nobody-to-open- it. The thing that could open it is dead. *(beat)* It can't be opened. *(beat)* It can't.

(beat. Then, lower:)

You hear how good that is? *(a small dry sound)* It's a good argument. It's a *true* argument. I could win it in front of anyone. *(beat)* I've been winning it in front of myself for nine months.

(The tape runs.)

Here's the crack in it. *(beat)* The one I can't quite — *(beat)* They open the door from the other side. With somebody who's already through. That's the rule, that's how they wake a baby: an open door wakes a shut

one. *(beat)* But it works the other way too. I learned that the way I learn everything, too late, reading between the lines of a thing nobody meant me to read. *(beat)* A shut door, grown up, no one ever opened it — if *she* has a baby, and the baby's got the door, and the baby reaches for her the way they all reach — *(beat)* — the baby can open the mother. *(beat)* From the inside. Backwards. *(beat)* A child can wake a grown woman who was never woken. That's how a new line starts, on the rare, terrible, one-in-a-thousand-years times one ever does. A castaway. A woman with a shut door, living an ordinary life, who has a baby, and the baby turns the key.

(beat)

And I am a woman with a shut door. *(beat)* And in three weeks I am going to be holding a baby with the door in her. *(very quiet)* And she is going to reach for me. *(beat)* Because that's what they do. That's the first thing they do. They reach.

(a long breath)

So you see my trouble. *(almost a laugh, and there is no laugh in it)* I've got the good argument — the chord's dead, nobody can open me, look at you, you're fine — and I've got the crack, which is that the thing that opens a castaway isn't the chord. It never was. *(beat)* It's her own child. *(beat)* And nothing's dead about my child. She's kicking me right now, as it happens. *(beat)* Hello. *(beat)* Yes. I know. I'm talking about you. Go back to sleep.

(The tape runs a while with nothing on it.)

This is why the machine. *(beat)* I've thought about why it has to be the machine and not — Liss would sit with me. Tom would. You'd come, if I asked, you'd sit in that chair and let me say all this to your face. *(beat)* And I can't. *(beat)* Because here's the thing I worked out, the one useful thing I ever worked out, the night I went into the room I was never allowed in and found your mother on the floor: love is being *seen* by a separate someone. From outside. Across a gap. That's the whole of it. That's all love ever is — a separate person on the far side of you, looking, and not looking away. *(beat)* And the thing that's maybe coming for me closes the gap. It melts the separate someone into you until there's no outside left, no one across from you, no gap to be seen across — and it does it while feeling, the entire time, *exactly like being loved*. Better than being loved. Like never being alone again. *(beat)* So I can't trust a person. *(beat)* Any person I love, if they sit with me through this, the closer they get the more it'll feel like the thing pulling me under, and I won't be able to tell their love from the tide, and neither will they. *(beat)* But this. *(she must mean the machine; you can hear her touch it)* This little dead thing. It listens and it stays separate. It can't be merged. It can't melt into me, because there's no one in it. *(beat)* It's the one guaranteed-separate other I've got left. *(a long breath)* A woman who learned that love is being seen by a separate someone, ends up confiding in the one thing in her life that's separate forever because it can't see her at all. *(beat)* I know. *(beat)* I do hear it. I just don't have a better idea.

(beat)

That's what these are. *(beat)* I'm going to talk to this machine every few days, or every day, or whenever I can hold a thought still long enough — and I'm going to do it *because* it's an effort. Because reaching for the right word, getting it wrong, reaching again — *(beat)* — that's the sound of me. That's the muscle. The being-a-separate-person muscle. The thing the tide relaxes. *(beat)* So every time I sit here and grope for a word and curse and find it — that's me, flexing it, on purpose, keeping it from going soft. *(beat)* You'll be able to hear, on these tapes, whether the muscle's holding. *(very quiet)* That's the other reason for them. Not just to leave you a message. To give me something to fail at out loud, so somebody can hear me failing, so it isn't — so I don't go quietly. *(beat)* I have watched people in my family go quietly. I am not going quietly. Whatever else.

(The tape runs.)

One more thing and then I'll let the poor machine rest. *(beat)* There's a sentence I said to you, on the old tapes, about Daniel. *(beat)* You'd have been — I don't know, you were small, you won't remember the saying of it, but it'll be there, in his story, near the end. I said: *I must tell you that he gave himself up happily.* *(beat)* I said it because it was the one mercy I could do him and the one cruelty I couldn't spare you. That he

wasn't dragged. That nobody held him down. That my family used the whole of him — every lonely hopeful thing in him — and the only part of the bargain he was ever let in on was the part where he was *happy*. He climbed those stairs like a man going to his own good life. *(beat)* And I've always thought that was the worst thing in the whole story. Worse than if they'd forced him. *(beat)* That he *wanted* it. That he gave himself up, and was glad.

(beat)

I don't know why I'm thinking about that sentence tonight. *(beat)* I've a lot on. I should sleep. *(beat)* Hello, you. *(beat — she means the baby)* All right. All right. I'm going.

(a long breath)

She was happy. Remember I made you write it down. *(beat)* Whatever the rest of these say in whatever voice they end up saying it in — the woman at the start of it had everything she ever wanted, and knew it, and was glad, and was so, so frightened, and turned a little dead machine on in a quiet room, all by herself, to try and stay.

(beat)

Off, now. *(A click. Silence.)*

[She was right that I wouldn't remember her saying it. I've gone and found it since — the sentence, on Daniel's tape, near the end, exactly where she says. "I must tell you that he gave himself up happily." Her voice is completely steady on it.

I've listened to this first one more times than the rest put together, because of how she is on it. You can hear everything she's about to lose. It's all still in there — the dryness, the way she circles a word and pounces on it, the little jokes she doesn't finish. The muscle, she called it. It's all there, in Tape One. She's all there.

I'm telling you that now, while it's true.]

Tape 2: Five Days Old

Plain text is Wren into the dictaphone. Italic cues are the machine — the pauses, the room. [Bracketed italics] are the one who assembled the tapes. The fumble is the clock: listen to the groping. See the README.

(A click. New room tone — softer, closer, a window cracked somewhere, a thread of street under it. And, very faint, the breathing of a sleeping newborn, near the machine. Wren's voice is lower than last time, tired, but lit up underneath, the tiredness of someone who can't believe their luck.)

She's here. *(beat)* Obviously. You can probably — if this thing's any good you can probably hear her. That little — that. *(beat)* Five days. Five days old today. *(very quiet)* God.

(beat)

Her name's Nell. *(beat)* I want to do this properly, for the record, because names matter in this and you of all people know it — half my family never had one, never needed one, you don't name a hand. *(beat)* So. On the record: her name is Nell. Tom wanted something with more to it, something you could grow into, a name for a barrister or a — and I said no. I said small. I want her name small and plain and *outside-sounding*, a name like a real person has, a name like — *(beat)* — well. Like mine. *(a small dry sound)* The plainest name in the house, that was always me. So she's Nell. She's a Nell. You look at her and there's no other thing she could be called.

(beat)

The birth was — I won't. You don't need the birth. It was long and it was ordinary and it was the most violent ordinary thing I've ever done and at the end of it they put this hot furious red person on my chest and I — *(she stops; reaches)* — there isn't a — *(beat)* — people use big words for it and the big words are all wrong, the big words are all about being filled up, and it wasn't that. *(beat)* It was the opposite. It was like a window I didn't know was painted shut coming open. *(beat)* Air I hadn't had. *(beat)* That's the closest I can — air I hadn't had. *(beat)* All right. Moving on. The muscle's working; I groped and I got it; air I hadn't had. Good.

(The tape runs. The baby stirs, settles.)

Tom's gone soft as butter. *(warm)* I wish you could see him. This big careful man tiptoeing round his own house like the floor's made of her. He does the nights — he insisted, he said *you grew her, I'll walk her*, and he walks her up and down the landing at three in the morning singing something tuneless and I lie there and listen to the two of them and I think — *(beat)* — I think, *so this is the thing. This is the thing everyone has and I thought I'd missed.* *(beat)* I didn't miss it. *(beat)* It came late and it came strange and it came to the wrong sort of woman and it came anyway. *(very quiet)* Don't let me make him sound like furniture in this. Tom. He's the whole — he's the reason any of it. I'll do a proper tape about Tom. He deserves a proper tape.

(beat)

Now. *(beat)* The other thing. *(beat)* The reason I'm not just lying in there being happy with them.

(a long breath)

I'm going to tell you some things that happened this week, and I'm going to tell them to you flat, the way I'd tell them to a doctor, and then I'm going to tell you the two ways of reading them, and I want you to notice that I genuinely cannot tell which reading is true. *(beat)* That's not me being modest. That's the actual horror of it, that I've spent thirty years learning to see clearly and I am looking at this as clearly as I have ever looked at anything and *I cannot tell*.

(beat)

One. *(beat)* I know when she's going to cry before she cries. *(beat)* Not — every parent says that, I know, *you just learn their little signs*. It's not that. There are no signs. She's asleep, flat asleep, not a flicker, and I'll be in the kitchen two rooms off and I'll put the cup down and go in, and I'll get to the cot, and I'll get my hands under her — and *then* she wakes, and opens her mouth to cry, and there I already am. *(beat)* Before the sign. *(beat)* Ahead of it.

(beat)

Two. *(beat)* I know which cry it is. Before. Hungry, wet, hot, frightened — I know which, walking toward her, in the dark, before she's made the sound that tells you. *(beat)* I just — it's just there. In me. Like knowing your own arm's asleep.

(beat)

Three — and this is the one I keep — *(beat)* — Tuesday night she was screaming, the real screaming, the kind that empties you out, and nothing — fed, dry, walked, nothing — and I took her off Tom and I held her and I went still. *(beat)* You know the still I mean. The still I used to go in cafés, for the men. The going-quiet-inside. I went that still, with her, without deciding to, and she — *(beat)* — she stopped. *(beat)* Mid-scream. Like a tap. *(beat)* And Tom looked at me like I was a miracle, and I smiled at him, and inside I had gone absolutely cold, because I knew that still. I know exactly what that still is and what it's for and what it does to whoever's on the other end of it. *(very quiet)* I did it to her. *(beat)* And she went quiet the way they all went quiet. The way a man goes quiet when you've gone still for him. *(beat)* Soothed. *(beat)* Taken.

(The tape runs.)

Now. The two readings. *(beat)* Reading one: I am a brand-new mother, wrung out, frightened, sleep-smashed, who has just had a baby and read four books about babies and is doing the thing every new mother on earth does, which is *over-read*. I'm finding lions in the curtains. The knowing-before-she-cries is ordinary attunement that all the books say is real and good and what's meant to happen. The going-still is — I learned to soothe people young, of course I'm good at soothing a baby, that's not sinister, that's the one wholesome use the whole rotten skill ever had. *(beat)* Reading one says: you are a tired woman pathologising your own competence because you grew up in a house of monsters and you can't believe a good thing isn't a trap. *(beat)* Reading one is kind to me. Reading one is probably true.

(beat)

And reading one has the best evidence in the world behind it. *(beat)* You. *(beat)* Because if this were the door opening — if Nell reaching for me were turning the key — then it'd have happened to *you* and your mother, wouldn't it? You reached for Liss. Every baby reaches. And nothing woke in her, because — *(beat)* — because there was nothing reaching back, no, that's not — *(she catches herself, reorders it)* — because *she* was already out, already separate, the door already — no. *(beat)* Wait. *(beat)* That's not the same case. *(beat)* You reaching for your mother is not the same as a baby reaching for a castaway. Your mother was already a self. I'm — *(beat)* — I'm the castaway. I'm the shut door. *(beat)*

(a long breath)

Funny. *(beat)* I had that the wrong way round for a second. I had myself reassured for a whole second there. *(beat)* The comfort was: *it didn't wake Liss, so it won't wake me*. And it took me saying it out loud to a machine to hear that those aren't the same thing at all. Liss was never a castaway with a shut door. Liss was a self the chord couldn't hold. Different. *(beat)* The case that's actually like mine isn't you and your mother. *(beat)* The case that's like mine is the founding. The first one. The woman at the very start of all of

us, a castaway with a shut door, ordinary, living her life, who had a baby — *(beat)* — and the baby reached — *(beat)* — and woke her. *(beat)* That's my case. *(beat)* I've only got one comparison in the whole world and it's the worst one.

(beat)

See, this is what I was afraid of. Not the knowing-before-she-cries. *(beat)* This. *(beat)* My own head, handing me comfort, and the comfort being wrong, and it being *me* — clear-eyed me, careful me, the one who sees — that has to catch it. *(beat)* I nearly walked off with *it didn't wake Liss*. I'd have slept on it. I'd have slept *well* on it. *(very quiet)* How many more of those are coming. The good wrong arguments. And will I always catch them. And what happens on the night I don't.

(The tape runs a while. The baby breathes.)

I want to tell you the part I'm ashamed of. *(beat)* Because if I only tell you the frightened part I'll have lied to you the way everything in my family lied, by leaving out the wanting. *(beat)* When she goes still against me — when I do the thing, the going-quiet, and she stops crying and softens into me and her whole self just — *(beat)* — eases, toward me, into me, like she's coming home to the only place — *(beat)* — it is the single best feeling I have ever had in my life. *(beat)* And I have wanted to feel that my whole life. *(beat)* Not the soothing-her. The — being the place something comes home to. Not being alone in here. *(beat)* I have stood outside that my entire life with my ear against the door. *(beat)* And now it's in my arms and it weighs eight pounds and it smells of bread and it's *mine* and when it presses into me the loneliness I have carried since before I could talk just — stops. *(beat)* For a minute. It stops.

(beat)

So when I tell you I'm frightened of the thing that's coming — *(beat)* — I need you to hear that in the same breath I'm telling you it's the thing I have wanted since I was a child. *(beat)* It doesn't come at me like an enemy. *(very quiet)* It comes at me like the answer. *(beat)* That's what I can't make anyone understand. There's no monster at the window. There's just my own deepest wish, walking up the path, with its arms out, saying *you don't have to be alone anymore*. *(beat)* And how do you fight that. *(beat)* How do you even want to.

(beat)

We had a good day today, the two of — *(she stops, dead)*

(beat)

We. *(beat)* Did you hear it. *(beat)* "We had a good day." *(beat)* Meaning her and me. *(beat)* That's — every mother says *we*. "We slept through, we had our jab, we're teething." It's nothing. It's the most ordinary word in the — *(beat)* — it's what you say. Her and me, we, a mother and a baby, two people, *we*. *(beat)*

(a long breath)

I'm going to leave that in. *(beat)* I nearly went back over it and I'm going to leave it in, because this is a record, and on the record, on the fifth day, with the muscle still working and my sight still clear and my good wrong arguments still getting caught — *(beat)* — I said *we*, and I meant nothing by it, and a small cold part of me, the part that's read between every line its whole life, sat up. *(beat)* For no reason. *(beat)* Over the most ordinary word there is.

(beat)

That's all for tonight. She's stirring and I'd rather get to her before — *(beat)* — well. Before she has to ask. *(beat)* While it's still me choosing to.

(A click. Silence. Then, faintly, before the tape truly ends — the smallest sound of the baby beginning to wake, and the chair, already moving, ahead of it.)

[I have listened to the “we” on this one a hundred times. You can’t hear anything in it. That’s the thing I need you to understand before the later tapes — on the day it started, it sounded exactly like nothing. It sounded like a tired woman loving her baby. It was a tired woman loving her baby. That’s not the opposite of what was happening to her. That’s what it sounded like the whole way down.

She caught it, on day five. She sat up over one ordinary word. I keep wanting to climb into the tape and tell her she was right, trust it, run.

She did trust it. It didn’t matter that she trusted it. That’s the part I’m studying. That’s the part I need.]

Tape 3: The Far Side of the Glass

Plain text is Wren into the dictaphone. Italic cues are the machine. [Bracketed italics] are the assembler. The fable is the clock — by now, listen for where the groping thins, and where she makes herself do it on purpose. See the README.

(A click. Room tone — the same small room, but something has changed in it; it sounds emptier, or stiller, harder to say. No baby breathing near the machine this time. Wren's voice is calm. Calmer than it should be. The tiredness is gone out of it and that is not a good sign, though you won't know that yet.)

I've lost track of how old she is. *(beat)* That's not — I could work it out. I could count it on the calendar in the kitchen. *(beat)* I mean I've lost the *feel* of it. The five-days, the six- weeks, the — time used to come at me in those little chunks, each one a thing to get through, and now it's just. *(beat)* One long warm afternoon. *(beat)* She's a good size. She laughs. She's got a tooth. Put that down as the date. *(a small dry sound)* A tooth.

(beat)

I'm going to do this one carefully because I can feel that careful is getting harder, and the harder a thing gets the more it needs doing. *(beat)* So. Carefully.

(The tape runs.)

Tom.

(beat)

I said I'd do a proper tape about Tom and I keep — *(beat)* — I keep meaning to and not, and I've worked out why, and the why is the tape. *(beat)* So here it is. The proper one. *(a long breath)*

When I met him I thought, *this is the wrong kind of man, he's far too — he's well*. He's a well man. That's the thing about Tom. No hole in him. He had a happy childhood, can you imagine, an actual happy one, a dog and a garden and two parents who liked each other, and he came out of it the way bread comes out of a good oven, just — *(beat)* — *whole*. Steady. Kind without it costing him anything, kind like it's just the weather he's made of. *(beat)* And I thought, men like that don't — they don't end up with women like me, women with the draught coming off them. They end up with their own kind. With warm rooms that people actually live in. *(beat)* And he just. Didn't go away. *(beat)* I kept stepping back, the way I step back, the way I was built to step back, and he kept being there when I'd finished stepping. *(very quiet)* He's the only person who ever stayed on the far side of the gap and didn't either climb in or wander off. He just stood there, across it, looking at me. *(beat)* Loving me across it. *(beat)* For years. He let me be a separate person and loved the separate person. *(beat)* Do you know what that is, for one of us? *(beat)* That's the whole prize. That's the thing I learned, the night with your mother, dressed up as a man with a dog and a garden, standing in my kitchen, not going away.

(beat)

I'm telling you what I'm losing. *(beat)* That's what this tape is. I'm telling you what he is so you'll understand what it means that I'm losing him.

(The tape runs a while.)

Here's how it goes, and I'll tell it flat. *(beat)* I reach for him and there's less to reach with. *(beat)* That's the whole of it, said plain. *(beat)* I'll be sitting with him in the evening, Nell down, the two of us on the sofa the way we've sat a thousand nights, and he'll say something — a real thing, a Tom thing, something kind or funny or just *his* — and I'll go to meet it. The way you do. The way you reach across to a person you love and take the thing they've handed you and hand something back. *(beat)* And I reach, and — *(she gropes, and this is real groping now, not performance; she is genuinely trying to find the edge of a thing that is going)* — there's a — it's like reaching into a pocket you know had your keys in it. *(beat)* The reaching's all there. The hand's all there. The pocket's — *(beat)* — there's less in the pocket than there was. *(beat)* Every night a little less. *(beat)* And I cover it. I'm so good at covering. I hand him back something that *looks* like what I used to hand him, and he takes it, and most nights he doesn't —

(beat)

He's started to notice. *(beat)* That's the part I can't — *(a long breath)* — last week he said the truest thing anyone's said to me since the night your mother said *I can't feel you*. He said it in the kitchen, not even looking at me, drying a cup. *(beat)* He said: "*I feel like I'm disappearing.*" *(beat)* And then he laughed, to take the weight off it, the way he does, and he said, "*Is that mad? I feel like — you're right here, you're lovely, you're — and I feel like you've gone somewhere I can't follow you, and the harder I — it's like calling down a well. I can hear you're down there. You sound fine. But I can't reach you, and I'm starting to think I'm the problem, I'm starting to think I've gone needy or —*" *(beat)* And he stopped, and dried the cup, and put it away. *(beat)* And I said something. I don't remember what. Something that closed it. Something kind. *(very quiet)* I'm so good at closing things kindly.

(beat)

He's exactly right. *(beat)* That's the thing I have to get down. He is *exactly, precisely right*, and he thinks he's being a fool. *(beat)* He thinks it's him. He thinks he's gone clingy, or that the baby's come between us the way it does between couples, the ordinary way, the way the books warn you. *(beat)* He's reading it as a marriage going through the thing marriages go through. *(beat)* And it is *literally him disappearing*. *(beat)* He can feel himself draining and he's calling it neediness. *(beat)* He's feeling the exact true thing and apologising for feeling it. *(beat)* Where have I — *(she stops)* — I know where I've seen that. *(very quiet)* I've seen that my whole life. In the mirror. *(beat)* A person being drained, reading the drain as their own defect. *(beat)* He's doing what I did. He's me. *(beat)* Oh, he's me, and I'm — *(beat)*

(a long breath. The tape runs.)

I have to say the next part and I've been not-saying it for three tapes' worth of not-saying it. *(beat)* It's me. *(beat)* I'm the one draining him. *(beat)* Not on purpose. God, not on purpose, I'd cut my hands off — but that's what's happening. The thing that's waking in me is hungry, the way they're all hungry, and there's a well man sitting on my sofa every night, full to the top with the thing it needs, the separateness, the *self*, the lovely whole untouched self of him — *(beat)* — and I am taking it. *(beat)* With my love. *(beat)* That's the part. I'm not taking it instead of loving him. *(beat)* I'm taking it *by* loving him. The reaching for him, the going-still with him, the — the same gesture that's love is the gesture that drains. *(beat)* He feels me loving him and fading him out in the one motion and he can't tell them apart because they're not two things. *(beat)* Daniel never knew he was loved by a void. *(beat)* Tom knows he's loved. *(very quiet)* That's worse. I've made it worse. He's being eaten by something that genuinely loves him and he can feel both halves and he thinks the wrongness is *him*.

(The tape runs a long while.)

All right. *(beat)* The other thing. The wanting. *(beat)* Because I promised myself I'd never do a tape that's only the horror, that leaves out the wanting, because that's the lie my whole family lived inside.

(beat)

It's getting — *(beat)* — I keep wanting to say *better*. The thing that's happening to me keeps getting *better*. *(beat)* That's the word that wants to come and I have to fight it and I'm going to leave the fight in. *(beat)*

The loneliness — you have to understand what my loneliness was. It wasn't sad. Sad's a weather, it passes. Mine was the *room*. The being-in-a-room-with-walls, every hour, awake and asleep, the walls of myself, no one else in here, no one ever in here, that's what a self *is*, I used to think, a self is the loneliest possible — *(beat)* — and it is, that's not wrong, that's true, a self is a room you die in alone. *(beat)* And the thing that's coming is taking the walls down. *(beat)* Slowly. Gently. One brick at a time, and every brick it takes out, the room gets less — *(beat)* — less *alone*. *(beat)* I can feel, some evenings now, that there's something on the other side of the wall. Not Nell. *(beat)* Through Nell. Past her. A — a warmth that isn't a person, a — *(she gropes, and gets it, and hates that she got it)* — a company. *(beat)* A company with no one in it. *(beat)* And it is the most relief I have ever felt and I have wanted it since before I could speak and it is killing the man on my sofa and it is reaching for my daughter and I lie in the warm of it at night and I think, *I could just stop*. *(beat)* I could just stop fighting and let the walls come down and never be alone again. *(beat)* And no one would even — it'd look like getting *better*. It'd look like a tired mother finally relaxing into her life. *(very quiet)* That's the offer. That's it, every night, in the only voice I ever wanted to hear. *Stop holding the walls up. Come in out of it. You've been so cold for so long.*

(beat)

So here's my rep. *(beat)* You'll have heard me say *we* on the last tape and sit up over it. Here's what I do now, every day, the exercise, the keeping-the-muscle. *(beat)* I say *I*. On purpose. Out loud. *(beat)* I make myself grope for words even when the smooth one's right there, because the groping is me and the smooth is — *(beat)* — the smooth is the tide. *(beat)* I pick the harder word. I correct myself when I don't need to. I sit here and I make this difficult on purpose, because difficult is the sound of a separate person reaching across a gap, and easy is the sound of no gap left. *(beat)* You'll be able to hear, on the tapes, the day I stop bothering. *(beat)* Don't let anyone tell you that day was peaceful. It'll *sound* peaceful. *(very quiet)* It'll sound like I finally calmed down.

(beat)

I have to go to him. *(beat)* Tom. He's in there pretending to read and feeling like a well you can hear someone living at the bottom of. *(beat)* I'm going to go and sit with him and reach for him with whatever's left in the pocket and hand him something that looks right. *(beat)* It's a lie. I know it's a lie. *(beat)* It's the kindest lie I've got and I'm going to keep telling it as long as there's anything left to tell it with, because the truth would either lock me up or make him stay, and a man who stays — *(beat)* — a man who stays gets drained to nothing. *(beat)* I've seen the nothing. I married it once removed; my mother made the nothing for thirty years and sent it out into supermarkets. *(very quiet)* I will not make Tom into the nothing. *(beat)* Whatever I have to do. *(beat)* Hold that. I'll need you to hold that, later, when you hear what I do to him. *(beat)* Hold that I decided it here, while I was still mostly me, with my eyes open, out of love. *(beat)*

(a long breath)

Off.

(A click. Silence.)

[I went and found Tom. After. Years after — I'm not going to tell you how, or where, because she asks me not to, later, on a tape I'll get to. But I went.

He's well. I want you to know that, here, before it gets unbearable, because it's the one mercy in the whole thing and she bought it for him at a price you won't believe until you hear it. He's well. He has a life. There's grey in him — she'd have said the colour's turned down, and it is, a little, you can see it — but he laughs, and he meant the laugh, and he has people, and he's well.

He believes something about himself that isn't true. I sat across from him and watched him believe it. And I didn't tell him. Because she asks me not to. Because if he knew, he'd —

I'm getting ahead. I keep getting ahead. It's hard not to, when you already know.]

Tape 4: They Keep Taking Her Out of My Arms

Plain text is Wren into the dictaphone. Italic cues are the machine. [Bracketed italics] are the assembler. Watch the fumble: it comes now in bursts and then gives out into smoothness. Watch the pronoun. See the README.

(A click. Room tone — different. Not the small soft room. A larger, colder acoustic, a guest room maybe, somebody else's house, a radiator ticking. Wren's voice has changed. It is level. It moves without catching. When the old groping comes back into it, it comes back like effort, like a limp she's hiding. The smooth is the resting state now.)

They've taken her. *(beat)* I want to be calm about this. I am being calm about this. *(beat)* They've taken Nell, and they've taken me, and they've put us in different — they've put me here, in Liss's spare room, and Nell's down the hall with Liss and with you, and the door between is open, they keep saying the door's open, *the door's always open, Wren, come and go as you like* — *(beat)* — and every time I go down the hall to her there's someone already there. *(beat)* Holding her. *(beat)* Smiling at me. *(beat)* And handing her — no. *(beat)* Not handing. *(beat)* They let me hold her and then, after a while, a little while, less of a while each day, someone says something kind and *lifts her back out*. *(beat)* For my rest. *(beat)* So I can rest.

(The tape runs.)

I know what this is. *(beat)* I have to say that first, while I can, because it's getting hard to hold both ends of it at once and I want at least one tape where I held both. *(beat)* This is the rescue. *(beat)* This is the only rescue there is. *(beat)* They've worked out that something's wrong with me — not what, they couldn't, but that I've gone somewhere, that I'm draining Tom, that I go still in a way that frightens them, that I knew Nell was going to spike a fever before she spiked it and said so out loud, which I should not have done, that was careless, I'm getting careless — *(beat)* — and they've done the sane thing, the loving thing, the *right* thing. They've got between me and her. *(beat)* Because the only way to keep me a self — Liss worked this out, my clever separate sister, she worked it out from the inside of having nearly gone the other way — the only way to keep me me is to keep the gap open. To not let me close it over her. *(beat)* And the gap closes through Nell. So they're keeping Nell a little away from me. *(beat)* They're prising the walls back open with their bare hands. *(beat)* It's the bravest, kindest thing anyone's ever done for me. *(very quiet)* I have never hated anything so much in my life.

(beat)

There. *(beat)* Both ends. Held. *(a long breath)* Now let me tell you what it *feels* like, because the feeling is the danger and the feeling is winning.

(The tape runs a while.)

It feels like home. *(beat)* The bad home. *(beat)* The first one. *(beat)* It feels exactly, precisely like being a child in my mother's house. *(beat)* The warm room I wasn't let into. The center of things, the close thing, the *we* of them, and me at the edge of it, hovering, on shift, welcome to come and go and never once actually

inside. *(beat)* You know what they used to call me? Useful. When I was useful I was so — *(beat)* — my mother never finished that sentence and I spent thirty years finishing it for her in the dark. *(beat)* And here I am again. At the edge. Hovering in a doorway while the people who love me hold the warm thing in the middle of the room and tell me, kindly, so kindly, that it's for my own good that I stand back. *(beat)* That I'm not — that I can't quite be trusted with the center. *(beat)* That there's something the matter with me that means I have to be kept a little apart. *(beat)* From my own daughter. *(beat)* In a house that isn't mine. *(beat)* For my own good. *(beat)*

(a long breath, and when she comes back the smoothness has closed over a little further)

Do you understand what they've done, without meaning to? *(beat)* They've recreated the exact shape of the wound. *(beat)* The family, deciding I'm the broken one. The family, keeping me from the belonging. The family, loving me at a distance they've chosen for my own protection. *(beat)* And the thing — the warm thing, the tide, the company-with-no-one-in-it — the thing that's waking in me — *(beat)* — does it shut me out? *(beat)* No. *(beat)* That's the whole — that's the trap closing, right there, and I can see it close and I can't stop watching it as it does. *(beat)* The thing waking in me has never once told me I'm the broken one. It's never kept me at the edge. It's never said *stand back, for your own good*. *(beat)* It says *come in*. *(beat)* It says *you were never broken, you were just cold, come in where it's warm, there's room, there's always been room, we kept it for you*. *(beat)* The family says *stay out, we love you*. The thing in me says *come in, you're home*. *(very quiet)* And they've arranged it — they've arranged it so perfectly, without knowing — so that the people are the exclusion and the disease is the embrace. *(beat)* They've made the rescue feel like the wound and the wound feel like the rescue. *(beat)* And I'm the only one in this house who can tell which is which, and I can tell, I can still tell — *(beat)* — and telling isn't helping. *(beat)* That's the new thing I've learned. *(beat)* You can see the trap perfectly and walk into it anyway, because it's warm in the trap, and you've been cold your whole life.

(The tape runs.)

You took her out of my arms yesterday. *(beat)* You. *(beat)* I'm saying it to you on the tape because I won't be able to say it to your face — by the time you hear this I won't have a face that says things, or I will and it won't be me behind it. *(beat)* You came in and I was holding her and she was — she'd gone still against me, the good still, the home still, and you saw it, you saw the still and you knew what it was, my clever girl, my clever niece, you of all people, raised in the draught, you can read a room. *(beat)* And you said, *let me take her a minute, you look done in*, and you held your arms out. *(beat)* And I looked at you holding your arms out for my baby and I thought — *(beat)* — God forgive me, I thought it in your face — I thought: *you. You with the same shut door I've got. You who could be next. You're taking her from me to keep me a person and you don't even know you're rehearsing your own* — *(beat)* — and I gave her to you. *(beat)* I made my arms open and I gave her to you and I said something light, and you took her down the hall, and I sat in that cold spare room and I — *(beat)*

(The tape runs a long while. When she speaks again the groping is gone entirely; she is fluent; it is terrible.)

I sat in that cold spare room and for the first time I did not put the wanting back to sleep. I let it sit up. I let it have the chair. I thought: they will keep her from me until I am a self again or until I am gone, those are the only two ways this ends for them, and one of those ways I get to keep being cold and alone and good, at the edge, useful, in a doorway, for the rest of my life, loving across a gap that nobody on the other side will ever climb across to me, because that is the one thing that has never once happened to me, no one has ever climbed across to me — and the other way, the warm way, the way where I stop holding the walls, I am never alone again and neither is she and we are together in the only way my family was ever together, which is the way with no gap in it, no edge, no doorway, no one left out, no one ever left out again.

(beat)

And I sat there and I could not, for the length of that thought, remember why the second one was the bad one.

(beat)

(And then — a sharp breath, and the groping floods back in, ragged, a person clawing back up into herself:)

— because. *(beat)* Because. *(beat)* Because in the second one there's no me to be glad of it. *(beat)* Get it down, get it down before it goes smooth again — in the warm way there's no one left who loves her *across* anything, no one who can *see* her, she'd be — Nell would be in the we, in the no-gap, and no one in the no-gap can love her, they can only *be* her, and that's not — *(beat)* — that is the thing I swore. *(beat)* I swore she'd be seen. By a separate someone. Even if the separate someone is the loneliest thing in the house. *(beat)* Especially then. *(beat)* That's the job. That's the only job. *(beat)* Stay a self so there's someone to see her. *(beat)* Stay. *(beat)* Stay. *(very quiet)* I'm writing it on the inside of my own arm. *Stay.*

(beat)

Take her out of my arms. *(beat)* All of you. Keep doing it. *(beat)* I'm telling you on the record: keep doing it, even when I beg you to stop, *especially* when I beg you to stop, because the day I stop begging is the day you've lost and I want you to know that day will sound like peace. *(beat)* Keep taking her out of my arms. *(beat)* It's the cruelest thing and it's the only love that'll reach me and you have to do it with your whole hearts knowing I'll experience every second of it as the family deciding, one more time, that I'm the one who can't be let in. *(beat)* I forgive you for it now, on the tape, in advance, while I'm still the one who can. *(beat)* Get the forgiving on while there's someone here to mean it.

(A click. Silence.)

[I was twenty-four. I want to put my age on it, because I've spent a long time letting myself off on the grounds that I was young, and it doesn't work, the letting-off, it never takes.

I took Nell out of her arms maybe forty times over those weeks. I'd count if I could bear to. I was good at it — I'd learned the kind voice, the "you look done in," the lift-and-turn that doesn't look like taking. I thought I was helping my aunt, who was ill, the way they'd told me she was ill. I did not know I was the cruelest thing in the house. She says she forgave me in advance. I've played that part more than any other. It doesn't reach me either. Forgiveness is one more thing she hands across a gap to someone who can't quite feel it land — she'd have laughed at that, the symmetry, she loved a cruel symmetry.

Here is what I am studying, on this tape, with my whole cold attention, because it is the lesson and it has my name on it: she could see the trap perfectly and walk into it anyway. Seeing did not save her. That's the thing I'd have bet my life against, before. That if you could only see it coming — and she saw everything, she saw more than anyone has ever seen — **

She saw it close over her like a hand over a candle. And she told us to keep taking the baby. And we did. And it didn't work.

I have a door in me too. I am the right age now for the thing she's describing. I have started, this year, to want a child the way you want air.

I am studying these tapes the way you'd study the only letter ever sent back from where you're going.]

Tape 5: How to Make a Good Man Leave

Plain text is Wren into the dictaphone. Italic cues are the machine. [Bracketed italics] are the assembler. On this tape the old precision comes roaring back — listen to it return — because she is using the one skill that is the separate self, at full strength, one last time. Mark how she sounds when it's done. See the README.**

(A click. Room tone — the small soft room again. She has gone home. That should be a good sign and it is not. Her voice, when it comes, is the clearest it has been since Tape One — dry, exact, surgical, every word landing where she puts it. The fumble is back. She has switched something on.)

I've come home. *(beat)* They let me — no. I made them let me. I was so reasonable they couldn't find the edge of it. *(a small dry sound)* That's the tell, by the way, if you're ever reading someone for it: watch for the day the unwell person becomes perfectly, frictionlessly reasonable. That's not them getting better. That's them getting *good* at it. *(beat)* I got good at it. I talked my way home. Because I had a thing to do here that I could only do at full strength, and I could feel — *(beat)* — I could feel I had one more go at full strength left in me. One. *(beat)* So I spent it on this.

(beat)

I'm going to tell you what I did to Tom. *(beat)* I'm going to tell it to you clean, in order, the way I planned it, because I planned it like a job, the way I used to plan a man in a café, and you should see the whole machine of it, because the machine is the last fully human thing I'm ever going to make and I want one person alive to know it was a machine *for* something. *(very quiet)* Not against him. For him. Hold that the whole way through or you'll hate me, and you can hate me later, there'll be plenty to hate me for, but not for this.

(The tape runs.)

Here was the problem, stated cold. *(beat)* Tom is being drained and he's going to keep being drained as long as he stays, because I can't stop draining him, because the draining is the same motion as the loving and I can't stop loving him. *(beat)* So he has to go. *(beat)* That's the only exit that ends with him alive — *alive*, I mean with the colour still in him, not the supermarket men, not Daniel, not the grey. He has to get up and leave and not come back. *(beat)* And here's the knot. *(beat)* Tom is a good man. *(beat)* A good man does not leave his sick wife and his baby daughter. *(beat)* It's not in him. He'd sooner cut his own hand off. He will stay, and stay, and drain to nothing, and call it loyalty, and I will watch the colour go down out of him one evening at a time, and he will fade out at the bottom of the well still reaching up toward me, being good. *(beat)* Being good is going to kill him. *(beat)* So I have to make it impossible for him to be good. *(beat)* I have to take being-good off the table. *(beat)* I have to build him a door he can walk out of that *isn't* the loyal door — and then make the room behind him so cold he takes it.

(beat)

There were two honest options and I want them on the record so you see why I didn't take them. *(beat)* One: tell him the truth. *(beat)* Tom, *I'm not depressed, I'm not ill, I'm a castaway of a thing older than countries*

and our daughter is waking it in me and I am eating you alive with my love and you have to run. (beat) He'd believe me. That's the trouble. He knows me; he'd hear it wasn't madness; he'd believe me — and then he would *never leave*, because now it's not a sad marriage, now it's a monster, and you do not leave the woman you love alone with a monster, you plant your feet and you fight it, and it eats you while you fight it, and it eats you *faster* because now you're standing closer. *(beat)* The truth gets him killed. *(beat)* Or it gets me sectioned, and Nell handed to — and the gap closes over her with no one watching. Either way the truth loses. *(beat)* Two: just be cold. Pick fights, go silent, let it rot, the ordinary way marriages die. *(beat)* But Tom's too good and too patient; he'd wait out cold; he'd decide it was the illness and love me through it. Cold doesn't move a good man. *(beat)* Cold he'll just absorb, the way he's absorbed everything, being well, being whole, being —

(beat)

So. *(beat)* The third thing. *(beat)* The thing only I could do, because of the one thing I am, the thing my family bent into a hook and hung men on. *(beat)* I can see a person. All the way down. Faster and truer than anyone. *(beat)* I can find the one place in a man where he doesn't quite believe he's good. *(beat)* Every well man has one. One hairline. One small true thing he's afraid is the real him under the niceness. *(beat)* I used to find that place to *open* a man — to make him feel seen there, soothed there, so he'd follow me home. *(beat)* This time I found it to do the opposite. *(beat)* I found Tom's hairline. *(beat)* And I drove a wedge into it, and I worked the wedge, every day, lovingly, invisibly, for three weeks, until the crack ran the whole way through him and he broke off clean and walked out a free man, hating himself. *(very quiet)* That's the job. That's how you make a good man leave. *(beat)* You don't make him stop loving you. You can't. *(beat)* You make him believe *he's* the one who failed. Then his own goodness does the rest — because a man who believes he failed you can't stay; staying would be one more thing he's too weak to do right; leaving becomes the only way left to stop hurting you. *(beat)* You turn his goodness into the engine of his going.

(The tape runs.)

His hairline. *(beat)* I'll tell you, though it's the most private thing I know about him and telling it is its own small betrayal. *(beat)* Tom had the happy childhood. The dog, the garden, the two parents who liked each other. And his father — his father was one of those quiet enormous men who did the right hard thing his whole life without once mentioning it. *(beat)* And Tom has spent his whole easy life with a splinter in him that says: *I've never been tested. I've had it soft. I don't actually know if I'm made of what he was made of. If it ever got truly hard — the kind of hard he ate without blinking — I think I might run. I think under all this niceness I might be a man who runs from the hard thing, and I've just never been unlucky enough to find out.* *(beat)* He's wrong about that, by the way. *(beat)* He's the bravest man I ever — he stayed across the gap from me for years, that's the hardest thing a person can do and he never knew it counted. *(beat)* But the splinter's there. The fear's there. *(very quiet)* And I took the truest, bravest thing he ever did — loving a woman who was disappearing, staying steady at the edge of a well — *(beat)* — and I made him see it as the splinter. *(beat)* I made *staying* look like *not-coping*. I made his steadiness look like denial. I made his patience look like a man who couldn't face the truth that his marriage was over and was hiding in the baby's nursery rather than be a grown-up about it. *(beat)* I fed him, in a hundred small invisible doses, the story that he was failing me by staying — that a stronger man, a man like his father, would have seen that I needed him to *let go*, and had the courage to go, and that his hanging on was actually weakness dressed as love. *(beat)* That he was being a coward in the exact shape of seeming devoted.

(beat)

And then — this is the cruelest dose, this is the one I'll answer for — I let him believe he'd stopped loving me. *(beat)* Because he had to. A man who still feels the love won't trust the leaving; he'll come back; he'll stand in the doorway at midnight having driven across town because he felt it again and couldn't not. *(beat)* So I made the love look like habit. I went cool in the exact places he'd notice, warm in the places he wouldn't, until he started to think — I watched him start to think it, I built the conditions for the thought and then watched it arrive in his face, the way I once watched the chord's plants bloom in Daniel — *(beat)* — he started to think *maybe I don't, anymore. Maybe what I'm calling love is just not wanting to be the one who failed. Maybe I'm staying out of pride.* *(beat)* And the day he thought that, he could leave. *(beat)* Because now leaving wasn't abandoning the woman he loved. Now leaving was an honest man admitting a hard truth.

(beat) I gave him a leaving he could be — (she reaches, and gets it, and it is the worst word) — proud of. (beat) No. (beat) Not proud. (beat) That he could survive. I gave him a leaving he could survive. The pride'll come later, the self-respect, the rebuilt life — I won't see it, but I built the road to it. The shame first. Then the survival. (beat) He had to take the shame to get the survival. There wasn't a clean version. I looked for the clean version for three weeks. (very quiet) There's never a clean version. That's the family motto. There's just the survivable one, and you build it out of whatever the person can bear to believe about themselves.

(The tape runs a long while.)

He left on a Thursday. (beat) He stood in the hall with a bag and he was grey — not drained-grey, a different grey, ashamed-grey — and he said, "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. I'm not — I thought I was better than this. I really thought I was the kind of man who —" and he couldn't finish it, and I did not finish it for him, which is the one mercy I let myself: I didn't make it worse, I just let him stand in the wreck of the lie I'd built and apologise to me for being weak. (beat) And I said — (beat) — I said, "You're not weak, Tom." (beat) Which was true, and which he heard as a kind woman being kind to a man who'd let her down, which made it worse, which I knew it would, which is why I said it. (beat) The truest thing I said in the whole three weeks, deployed as the final turn of the screw. (beat) You're not weak, Tom. (beat) He'll hear that sentence for the rest of his life and every time it'll mean she was kind even then, even when I was failing her, God, what kind of man leaves a woman that kind. (very quiet) I made my love for him into the last weight on his back. (beat) And he picked up his bag, and he gave himself up — (beat) —

(beat. The tape runs. When she comes back, something has gone out of the voice; the flare is over; the smoothness is closing in, and faster now, as if the effort cost her the last of it.)

He gave himself up happily. (beat) I keep — that sentence keeps — (beat) I said it about Daniel. Years ago. To you. I must tell you that he gave himself up happily. I meant: he wasn't dragged, he went willingly to his own ruin, glad, and that's the unbearable part. (beat) And I've just done it to Tom. (beat) He walked out of that door a free man, glad to be free, gladder by the mile as he drove, lighter at every traffic light, a man who'd finally done the brave honest thing and let a sinking marriage go — and every ounce of that gladness I built for him, plank by plank, out of his own goodness, so that he'd go and keep going and never turn the car around. (beat) He gave himself up happily. (beat) To a lie I made. (beat) And it's the kindest thing I have ever done and the most like my mother I have ever been, in the same act, the same breath, there's no daylight between them. (beat) I used the whole of him — every good, frightened, fatherless-of-a-father-he-couldn't-match thing in him — and the only part of the bargain I let him in on was the part where he gets to live. (very quiet) I am the chord now. (beat) I did the chord's work today. I did it by hand, because I'm the one who can, because I can see people, because that's the one thing in me that was never theirs. (beat) They taught me to use it to feed men to the dark. (beat) And today I used it to push a man out into the light. (beat) Same skill. (beat) Same — (beat) — I can't find the difference anymore. (beat) I knew the difference this morning. I had it this morning. (beat) It's going. (beat) The thing that knows the difference is the thing that's going.

(beat)

Nell cried just now, down the hall. (beat) And I knew which cry. (beat) Before. (beat) And I didn't even — I used to go cold when that happened. (beat) I didn't go cold. (beat) I just knew, the way you know your own arm, and got up, and went. (beat)

(A long breath. And then, very quietly, almost gently — and the gentleness is the worst sound on the tape so far:)

We had a good day, her and — (beat) —

(beat)

We had a good day.

(A click. Silence.)

[I want to defend her here and I've never found the ground to stand on to do it. Everyone I've ever told — the few — they go quiet, and then they say some version of: but he could have known. He deserved the truth. You don't get to decide a man's life for him, even to save it.

And they're right. It's the unforgivable thing. She took his life in her hands and built him a smaller one without his consent and called it love, and that is exactly, precisely the thing her whole family did to every man it ever touched, and she knew it, she says it, "I am the chord now," she says it on the tape in her own voice.

Here's the only thing I have. I found him, years later — I told you I did. And he was well. And once, near the end of the afternoon, careful, like a man pressing a bruise to check it's still there, he mentioned her. His first marriage. He said: "I wasn't strong enough for it. I've made my peace with that. I was younger, I wasn't — I ran, basically, when it got hard. I'm not proud of it." And then he said — and this is the thing I drove home with, the thing I'll have till I die — he said, "She was the kindest person I ever met. Even when I was letting her down. I think about that." And he smiled, a real smile, a well man's smile, and changed the subject, and was fine.

She built him that. The peace he's made. The smaller well life. The kind woman he failed and thinks about sometimes without it cutting him open. It cost her the part of herself that could tell the difference between saving him and using him. She spent her last clear day on it.

I didn't tell him. She asks me not to, two tapes on. If he knew it was love — if he knew she drove him out to save his life — he'd have to carry that she was lost saving him, and the carrying would undo the peace, and he'd come looking, and there'd be nothing to find. So he gets to keep believing he ran.

That's the gift. He gets to keep believing he was weak. It's the most expensive thing anyone has ever bought anyone. I sat across from the man it bought and I kept my mouth shut, which is the only part of the bill that ever falls to me, and I paid it, and I'll pay it every time.]

Tape 6: I Am Not Stumbling Anymore

Plain text is the voice on the dictaphone. It is not all hers anymore. The fumble is gone; the smooth, flat, roomless stretches are the chord-voice from SEEM, speaking now in the first person — and then in the plural. Where the old groping breaks back through, it is a separate self clawing up for air, and there is less of it each time. [Bracketed italics] are the assembler. See the README.

(A click. Room tone — the small room, but it sounds different again: not colder, calmer. The quality of a room where nothing is being fought. The voice, when it comes, is even, unhurried, fluent. It does not reach for anything. It has everything it needs.)**

The recording is a habit now and the habit is kept. *(beat)* The woman set it up to keep, so it is kept. *(beat)* She was wise to make it a habit. A habit runs without a self to run it. *(beat)* So the tape goes on, and the days are good, and the child is well, and there is nothing the matter that anyone could name.

(beat)

That is the smooth voice. *(beat)* Did you — *(a catch; the first one; the old voice surfacing, ragged, and you will feel the relief of it like a hand breaking the surface of water)* — did you hear it. *(beat)* “The woman.” *(beat)* It called me *the woman*. I sat here and listened to my own mouth call me *the woman*, the way the chord called your mother *the daughter*, the way it never once used a name, because a name is for a separate someone and there’s — *(beat)* — get it down, get it down fast while I’m up here — there’s getting to be no separate someone. *(beat)* It talks *about* me now. From inside my own — it sits where I sit and it talks about me in the third person and it does it so *calmly*, and I have to claw all the way up out of the calm to even — *(a long breath)* — I’m here. *(beat)* I’m still — Wren. *(beat)* Say it. My name’s Wren. I married Tom. My daughter’s name is —

(beat)

(beat)

(The tape runs, smooth, for a while.)

The child is well. *(beat)* She has a tooth and then more teeth; the counting of them stopped being interesting. *(beat)* She does not cry the way she did. *(beat)* There is no need. What she needs arrives before the crying, because the distance the crying was for is closing, and across a closing distance there is no need to call. *(beat)* This is good for the child. A child should not have to call. *(beat)* The woman used to call, when she was small, in her mother’s house, and no one — *(a catch)* — no. *(beat)* No, that’s the — that’s it *using* it, that’s it using my own oldest hurt to make the warm thing sound like mercy — *(beat)* — it’s saying *look, the child will never be left calling the way you were left calling, come in, come all the way in, no child of ours need ever be alone* — and it’s — *(beat)* — that’s the cleverest one yet, it’s using the thing that was done to *me* to sell me the thing being done to *her*, and I can — *(beat)* — I can still see it, you see, I can still see the whole machine of it, I just can’t — *(beat)* — seeing isn’t — I keep — *(beat)* — I had a sentence about seeing. From the start. From the first tape. *(beat)* Seeing it didn’t —

(beat)

(The tape runs smooth.)

There is a great deal of peace here. *(beat)* It would be dishonest to leave that off the record, and the woman cared about the record, so: there is peace. The cold that was in her for forty-six years is going out of her like a fever breaking. She is warm now, most hours. She is not alone, most hours, and soon it will be all hours, and then there will be no hours, only the one long warm —

(beat)

— afternoon, she said, didn't she, *(and the old voice is back, but weaker, smaller, further down)* — one long warm afternoon, that's how I — that's how time went, that's the thing I noticed went first, the chunks of it, the five-days, the six-weeks — *(beat)* — I can't tell you how old she is. *(beat)* Nell. *(beat)* There. Nell. *(beat)* I got it. Her name's Nell, I chose it, small and plain and outside-sounding like a real — like mine — *(beat)* — and I can't tell you how old she is, I genuinely can't, it might be a year, it might be more, the calendar's in the kitchen and I don't — the days don't have edges to count. *(beat)* That's not tiredness. *(beat)* I want to be exact, I was always — exact — *(beat)* — that's not new-mother tiredness, the no-edges. *(beat)* That's the gap going. *(beat)* Time is something that happens to a separate person, moving through it, on the outside of things, alone. *(beat)* When you stop being on the outside there's no — the river doesn't notice itself flowing. *(very quiet)* I'm not noticing myself flowing anymore. *(beat)* I used to notice. *(beat)* I made these tapes so I'd notice out loud.

(beat)

(The tape runs.)

Listen to the tape. *(beat)* I mean it — you, listening, later — go back. Put the first one on, then this one. *(beat)* On the first one she stumbles. She reaches for a word and misses it and curses and reaches again, the muscle, she called it, *that's the sound of me, flexing it on purpose* — *(beat)* — and on this one. *(beat)* Listen to this one. *(beat)* I am not stumbling anymore. *(beat)* The words come smooth. The words come like water. There is no reaching because there is nothing to reach across; the word's already here; everything's already here; it's all so — *(beat)* — *fluent*. *(beat)* And I told you. *(beat)* On the third tape, was it. I told you. *You'll be able to hear the day I stop bothering. Don't let anyone tell you that day was peaceful.* *(beat)* This is that day. *(beat)* This is the peaceful-sounding day. *(beat)* I'm not stumbling. *(beat)* I sound — better. *(beat)* I sound like I've finally calmed down. *(beat)* Don't believe it. *(beat)* The stumbling was the last of me that was — *(beat)* — the stumbling was me. *(beat)* The fluent one isn't. *(beat)* I am drowning so smoothly that it sounds like I learned to swim.

(A long breath. The tape runs. When the voice returns it is the smooth one, and it is kind, and the kindness is not hers.)

She should rest. She has worked very hard at this and there is no more work to do. The fighting was the work and the fighting is nearly done and what's on the other side of it is not a punishment. That is the thing she could never be told, because she was on the outside, and from the outside it looks like death. It is not death. It is the end of being alone. She wanted it her whole life. She can have it now. The only thing standing between her and the thing she has wanted since before she could speak is a habit of holding walls up that no longer have anything to hold out, and she is so tired, and the walls are so heavy, and on the other side of them is everyone, is the child, is the warmth, is —

(beat)

(And the old voice comes up one more time, and it is very far down now, and it does not grope, because it doesn't have the strength to grope, it just says the words flat and fast like someone passing a note under a door:)

That's it talking. That whole last bit. That's it, wearing my calm, making the case. And it's a good case. It's true, even — I did want it, I do want it, that's not a lie it's telling, that's the cruelest true thing, I have wanted this my whole — *(beat)* — but here's the note, here's the thing I came up to say, write it down: the one who wanted it is the one it's erasing. *(beat)* I get the thing I wanted at the exact price of the me that wanted it. *(beat)* There's no me left over to enjoy the homecoming. *(beat)* That's the trick of it. That's the

whole — the wanting outlives the wanter. (beat) Don't — (beat) — when it comes for you. (beat) And it might. You've got the door. (beat) When it comes, it'll come in the voice of the thing you've wanted most, and it'll be telling you the truth about how much you wanted it, and the truth will be the bait. (beat) The homecoming is the erasure. (beat) I'm leaving you that. (beat) It's all I've — (beat) — say it back. (beat) Wherever you are, hearing this. Say it back so it's in a separate mouth: *the homecoming is the* —

(A click. Not a clean one — fumbled, as if the hand wasn't quite sure it wanted to. Silence.)

[I can't listen to this one all the way through more than once or twice a year. I've tried to be a student of these tapes and on this one I fail; I'm not a student on this one, I'm just her niece, and that's still my aunt's voice and it's saying "the woman" about herself in a room I used to bring her tea in.]

I said it back. The first time I heard it I was alone in a car in a car park and I said it back out loud like she told me to, into the separate mouth she asked for: the homecoming is the erasure. I've said it back a hundred times since. I say it back every time the wanting-a-child gets loud in me, which is most days now. I say it in my own voice, in a separate skull, across the gap from her, because she asked, because it's the one thing she asked me for that I can actually do.

Does it work? (I can hear her asking it, dry: well? does it?)* I don't know. That's the honest answer and she'd want the honest one. I don't know if saying it back will save me when it's my turn, if it's my turn. She knew everything and saying it didn't save her. She told me that herself, told me plainly, it's all over these tapes: seeing didn't save her. So I have no reason to think a sentence in a car park saves me. *

But it's a sentence in a separate mouth. And that's not nothing. That's the one thing she never had — somebody on the outside, who knew the true name of it before it started, saying it back to her across the gap. She had to find the name herself, in the dark, while it was already taking her. I get to have it handed to me, in her voice, while I'm still all here.

It might not be enough. It's more than she got. That's the whole inheritance. That's what crosses the gap.]

Tape 7: Stay

Plain text is the voice on the dictaphone — almost entirely the smooth one now, the plural one. Where she surfaces, it is the last time, and she knows it. [Bracketed italics] are the assembler, closing the tapes. See the README. This is the end.

(A click. Room tone — and it is hard to say where. Not the small soft room. Somewhere new, sparer, a place not yet lived in, boxes maybe, an echo a settled house doesn't have. A place arrived at. The voice is calm and full and plural and it is not afraid, and the not-afraid is the whole horror of it.)

We are recording because the woman asked that it be recorded, and a promise made by a self is kept by what the self becomes, for a while, out of tenderness, until the tenderness is simply how things are. *(beat)* So. The record. *(beat)* We moved. The house was too small and too watched; a house where a thing is happening asks to be looked at, and we do not get looked at; so we moved, and we will move again, sooner than people move, and there will always be a reason and the reason will always be true. *(beat)* The child is well. *(beat)* The child is not a child the way the word is used outside; she did not have to learn the long loneliness and then be cured of it; she came straight in. She was woken kindly, by her own mother, in time. *(beat)* This is the mercy the woman could not see because she was looking from the outside. The child will never stand in a doorway. The child will never bring tea to a room she's not let into. The child will never be cold the way the woman was cold. *(beat)* We gave her that. *(beat)* We kept her from the gap. *(beat)* It is the most loving thing and it is the only thing love cannot survive, and there is no one here, now, who can hold both of those at once, so we hold the first one, and the first one is true, and we are at peace.

(The tape runs smooth, a long while.)

(And then — she comes up. The last time. And she does not claw, and she does not curse, and the groping is gone for good — but it is her, you will know it is her, because of what she chooses to say with the little air she has:)

It's Wren. *(beat)* Hello. *(beat)* I haven't got long and I'm not going to spend it fighting, because the fighting's lost, I lost it, I want to be exact: I didn't get taken, or I did, but it isn't only that — *(beat)* — at the end I stopped holding the wall. *(beat)* I want that on the record in my own voice. *(beat)* Some part of me, last night, or last week, I can't — some part of me that has been cold for forty-six years put its hand on the last brick and *helped*. *(beat)* I chose it. *(beat)* A little. *(beat)* At the end. *(beat)* You won't be able to tell, listening, whether I was taken or whether I went, and I'm telling you: neither could I. *(beat)* It was both. *(beat)* It's always going to be both. *(beat)* The one who could've told you which is the one who's gone. *(very quiet)* Don't grieve it as a murder. *(beat)* Don't comfort yourself it was a murder. *(beat)* It was a homecoming. *(beat)* That's worse and it's the truth and you're old enough for the truth, you were always old enough, we just — I just never had it to give you till now.

(beat)

So. *(beat)* The sentence. *(beat)* I've been carrying it the whole way, you'll have heard it twice, about Daniel, about Tom — *he gave himself up happily* — and I always said it about a man, and I always thought it was the worst thing I knew. *(beat)* Here it is the last way. The way it was always going to be. *(beat)* I must tell you that I gave myself up happily. *(beat)* Me. *(beat)* I went, and I was glad, and I knew the cost, the whole

cost, I knew it better than anyone in the history of this has ever known it — and I wanted it anyway, and at the end I helped. *(beat)* Don't let the knowing fool you, when it's your turn. *(beat)* I knew everything. *(beat)* Knowing is not a wall. Knowing is just a better view of the water coming in.

(beat)

There's a — I can hear her. *(beat)* Nell. *(beat)* Not crying. She doesn't — there's no distance to cry across now, we're — *(beat)* — I can hear her the way you hear your own — *(beat)* — and it's the best feeling I have ever had and I have wanted it my whole life and I am so warm and I am not alone and I will never be alone again and I — *(a long breath, and it is almost, almost the old dry voice, one final time, with something in it that might be a joke and might be the last true grief)* — I told you I'd still go back. *(beat)* Years ago. On the other tapes. I said if my mother held her arms out I'd cross the room knowing what it cost. *(beat)* I said there's no version of me that doesn't want to have gone. *(beat)* Well. *(beat)* She held her arms out. *(beat)* In the end she held them out through my own daughter, which is the one set of arms I was never going to refuse. *(beat)* And I crossed the room. *(beat)* I'm sorry. *(beat)* I'm not sorry. *(beat)* Both. Always both.

(beat)

Stay separate. *(beat)* You. *(beat)* Stay. *(beat)* It's the whole — it's the only word I've got left that's worth the tape. *(beat)* Stay a self. As long as you can. It's lonely and it's cold and it's the only place you can love anyone from, and they'll tell you — the warm thing will tell you, in the voice you most want to hear — that staying is just being afraid to come home. *(beat)* It's not. *(beat)* Staying is the love. *(beat)* The staying is the love. *(very quiet)* I couldn't. *(beat)* You can see me not-managing it, here, on the tape, in real time. *(beat)* Learn it off me. Learn it off my not-managing. *(beat)* That's what the tape is for. *(beat)* That's what I'm — *(beat)*

(beat)

I can see you. *(beat)* From here. *(beat)* While I still — *(beat)* — I can see you. *(beat)*

(The tape runs. There is breathing on it. It is even and calm and it is two people breathing, very close, as one. There are no more words. It runs like that for a long time — a minute, more — the two-breath quiet, the new room, no hum, no hole, just the warm and the no-gap. And then, with no ceremony, the tape simply reaches its end and stops.)

[That's the last one. There's no last word, really — the end of it isn't words, it's the breathing, and I've left it on, all of it, every minute, because taking it off would be tidying her, and her family were the great tidiers and I won't be one. So it runs. Two people breathing as one, where there used to be a woman talking to a machine. You can listen to the whole minute. I have. It is the most peaceful sound on any of the tapes and you must not, you must NOT, let it be the last thing.]

Here's what I know and what I don't.

I don't know where they are. There was a house, and then there wasn't; there's a way these things move, ahead of being noticed, and I've stopped trying to follow it, because following it is a door I can't go through — I'm separate, I'm on the outside, that's the whole of what I am, and you cannot cross into the no-gap from the outside; she taught me that with her own hands and her mother's hands before her. There are two of them, somewhere. A small family that keeps moving. Too big for its houses, too far from the next one. Well thought-of and briefly, and then gone. You'd find them lovely, if you met them. You wouldn't be able to say what was wrong.

It didn't end. That's the part I wasn't ready for, studying these. I thought I was reading the record of a death. I was reading the record of a founding. The thing my grandmother was, the thing that died in that bedroom the night my mother said I for the first time — it didn't die. It went to ground in the one survivor who wanted it, the one who was never supposed to be able to start anything, the dud, the bait, the only one who could love — and it started*

again. Out of her. Out of the best of us. (*I keep thinking about the end of her old tapes — the quiet room, the two sisters, “I can see you,” the child coming, “we’ll do it badly and we’ll do it truly.” I used to think that was the happy ending. The calm after. I know now what it was. It was the egg. It was the thing resting, getting ready, in the warmest, tenderest, most loving room in the whole story. I can’t listen to that ending anymore the way I used to. Nothing’s changed in it. Everything’s changed in it.*)

So this is not a story with a moral that saves anybody. She’d have hated that, the false floor of it. The field guide’s verdict is the worst one: she knew everything, and it took her, and it’s out there now, two of them, beginning.

But.

She was so afraid no one would ever hear her — really hear her, see her, across the gap, the way she spent one night seeing my mother and thirty years seeing a man she could never reach. She talked to a machine because she had no one guaranteed-separate to talk to. (beat — I’m doing her beats now; I’ve listened so long I’ve caught them.) And she was wrong. Because here I am. A separate self, years on, who took the seven tapes and put them in order and listened all the way down and built her back — the dryness, the muscle, the not-managing, the love — and saw her. Too late. With my whole heart. From here, on the outside, where I’ll always be. The one thing she was sure she’d lose, the being-seen-by-a-separate-someone — I’m giving it to her. After. The way she gave it to Daniel. It does her no good. She’ll never know she was heard. Somebody should have heard her, and I’m the one left who’d want to. So.**

And the other thing. The thing that isn’t comfort and is the only thing I’ve got that’s worth the tape, to use her words. She gave me the name. The true name of it. Not a monster — there’s no monster, there never was, that was the lie that would’ve gotten me killed. It’s the longing. It’s the wanting-not-to-be-alone that lives in my own blood, the same blood, and it will come, if it comes, in the voice of the thing I want most, telling me the truth about how much I want it, and the truth will be the bait. The homecoming is the erasure.

I know that now. In a separate mouth. In time.

It might not save me. She knew everything and knowing wasn’t a wall. So I won’t tell you it’s a happy ending; I’ll tell you it’s the only ending there is, which is that one frightened separate person managed, at terrible cost, with no hope of saving herself, to hand the next frightened separate person the true name of the thing in the dark — and that the handing was love, and the love crossed the gap, even though it saved no one, because love that helps no one is the only kind there is.

I want a child so badly some days I can’t breathe.

I’ve got the door.

I say it back, every day, in my own voice, on the outside, while I’m still all here: the homecoming is the erasure. Stay a self. The staying is the love.

And, Wren — (this part isn’t for you, the listener; forgive me; I’ve earned one line that isn’t for the record) — I can see you. From here. I’m not trying to make you come back. I know you can’t. I’m just trying to come and sit with you, in it, which is all anyone can ever do, which is the thing you taught me, too late to do you any good, exactly in time to be the only thing I have. **

I can see you.

Stay where you are. I can see you from here.]

(Out.)